

Mahakali

Director: *Puja Aparna Kolluru*

Producer: *Riwaz Ramesh Duggal*

Date of release: *Jan. 8, 2027*

One of the few films to spotlight a goddess, this dark mythological fantasy film is part of writer Prasanth Varma's cinematic universe. Sriya Reddy plays the fierce Kali and Akshaye Khanna is Shukracharya. A pan-India release is on the cards.

Like *Dhurandhar – The Revenge,* the year's highest-grossing film so far, *Hanuman Ansh* too has become a cultural phenomenon, with footage of audiences removing their footwear or crying in cinemas circulating online. Among the devout fanbase is Jatin Mishra, an RJ by profession, who has seen the film thrice and hearts it for its "honesty and simplicity". "I like how baba gives a devotee practical advice to see a doctor when he complains of fever. It's not like he is some miracle man," he says. "There were scenes that gave me goosebumps and left me emotional."

The film's success has had a seismic effect. Kainchi Dham, the baba's shrine in Uttarakhand, is suddenly awash with such a tourist throng that the locals are peeved. Shobhinaw, who saw his role change from assistant director to leading man at the 11th hour, cannot walk the streets without a mask and cap on. When he does get recognised, people first touch his feet, then seek selfies. He responds with, "Sita Ram, Sita Ram." Sensing the immense opportunity, Sony Entertainment Television recently announced a show on Neem Karoli Baba. Producers are queuing up to register more devotional titles and announcing biopics on spiritual gurus; the latest being on Ramdev Pir and Devraha a.k.a. Machaan Baba. Bollywood, clearly, is under a divine spell.

The real biggie, though, has yet to come. With a budget as epic as the story itself—Rs 4,000 crore—*Ramayana* is poised to be this Diwali's biggest draw. It is a tale audiences never tire of hearing, starring a much-loved hero of the Hindu pantheon. Produced by Namit Malhotra's Prime Focus and actor Yash's Monster Mind Creations, it is the costliest film in Indian cinema. Devotion will undoubtedly be a lure, but the makers are also banking on spectacular visual effects and a star-studded cast: Ranbir Kapoor as Ram, Sai Pallavi as Sita, Sunny Deol as Hanuman, Yash as Ravan and Arun Govil—the original Ram of Doordarshan's cult television series *Ramayan*—as Dashratha. And this is only Part 1 of the 3D spectacle.



"Why are we not teaching Ramayana in our schools? We're learning British and Mughal history and what they did to us but not our history, the origin of where we come from"

Namit Malhotra, *Producer,* Ramayana, *in a conversation with Sadhguru*